

Little Explorers Learning Hub

Trees Study • Week One Lesson Plan

Getting to Know Trees

Children begin their investigation by exploring trees through observation, conversation, science, literacy, art, music, movement, and outdoor discovery.

Week at a Glance

Investigation

Observe trees using all five senses while learning new vocabulary and asking thoughtful questions.

Essential Question

What makes a tree a tree?

Vocabulary

Tree, Leaf, Branch, Roots, Trunk, Bark

Materials

Leaves, Sticks, Pinecones, Magnifying Glasses, Clipboards, Crayons

Monday

Introducing the Tree Study

Arrival Invitation

Invite children to explore baskets filled with leaves, bark, sticks, pinecones, acorns, and tree cookies. Encourage them to touch, compare, sort, and describe what they notice.

Materials: Leaves; Pinecones; Branches; Bark; Magnifying Glasses; Sorting Trays

Morning Meeting

Greeting

Good morning, explorers! Today we begin an exciting journey learning all about trees.

Question of the Day

Have you ever climbed a tree or played beneath one?

Discussion

What is a tree? Where do trees grow? Why are trees important? What do you already know about trees?

Read Aloud

Featured Book

A Tree Is Nice by Janice May Udry

Discussion Questions

What did you notice about the trees? How do trees help people? Who lives in trees? Why are trees important?

Small Group Investigation

Leaf Scientists

Children compare leaves by size, color, shape, texture, and smell while using magnifying glasses to observe details.

Materials: Leaves; Magnifying Glasses; Sorting Mats; Paper; Crayons

Teacher Prompts

Which leaf is the biggest? How are these alike? How are they different? What do you notice? What do you wonder?

Interest Areas

Blocks: Build a forest using wooden blocks and natural materials.

Art: Create leaf rubbings with crayons and different kinds of leaves.

Library: Explore books about trees, forests, and woodland animals.

Discovery: Observe bark, branches, leaves, and seeds with magnifying glasses.

Dramatic Play: Transform the center into a Forest Ranger Station.

Writing: Draw your favorite tree and tell a story about it.

Outdoor Exploration

Take a nature walk around the playground or school grounds. Observe different trees and compare their trunks, branches, bark, and leaves.

Look for birds. Find different leaf shapes. Touch the bark. Search for roots.

Music & Movement

Pretend to become a growing tree. Start as a tiny seed. Grow roots. Stretch into a tall trunk. Reach out with branches. Sway gently in the breeze.

Reflection Circle

What did you discover today? What surprised you? What would you like to learn about trees?

Family Connection

Invite families to take a walk together and find one tree near their home. Encourage children to notice the trunk, bark, branches, leaves, and anything living nearby. Ask them to share their discoveries tomorrow.

Tuesday

Looking Closely at Trees

Arrival Invitation

Invite children to compare several different leaves using magnifying glasses. Encourage them to notice veins, edges, colors, and shapes.

Materials: Collected Leaves; Magnifying Glasses; Sorting Mats; Clipboards

Morning Meeting

Question of the Day: Do all trees have the same leaves?

Discussion: Why are some leaves bigger? Why do leaves have different shapes? Why do leaves change color?

Read Aloud

Featured Book: Leaf Man by Lois Ehlert

Discuss how leaves come in many different colors, sizes, and shapes, and encourage children to identify similarities and differences.

Small Group Investigation

Leaf Sorting Challenge

Children sort leaves by color, size, shape, texture, or edge. Invite them to explain why they placed each leaf into its group.

Materials: Leaves; Sorting Trays; Paper; Crayons

Science Investigation

Fresh vs. Dry Leaves

Compare freshly picked leaves with dry leaves. Invite children to bend, twist, smell, and closely observe each one.

Which leaf bends? Which leaf breaks? Which one feels smoother? Which one is heavier?

Math Investigation

Leaf Measuring

Measure leaves using linking cubes, paper clips, or rulers. Compare the longest, shortest, widest, and narrowest leaves.

Materials: Leaves; Linking Cubes; Rulers; Recording Sheet

Interest Areas

Art: Create leaf collages using leaves collected during outdoor exploration.

Blocks: Build a forest filled with trees, animals, and walking paths.

Discovery: Observe leaf veins with magnifying glasses.

Library: Explore nonfiction books about forests and trees.

Writing: Draw and label different kinds of leaves.

Dramatic Play: Pretend to work at a nature center helping visitors identify leaves.

Outdoor Exploration

Return to yesterday's tree and compare today's observations. Has anything changed? Are there more leaves on the ground? Do you see birds? Do you notice insects?

Music & Movement

Pretend to be colorful autumn leaves blowing through the wind. Float slowly. Spin in circles. Dance with the breeze. Land softly.

Reflection Circle

How were today's leaves different? What surprised you? Which leaf was your favorite?

Family Connection

Invite families to collect three different leaves during an evening walk and bring them to school for tomorrow's investigation.

Wednesday

Discovering the Parts of a Tree

Arrival Invitation

Invite children to sort bark, branches, leaves, pinecones, acorns, and seeds according to the part of the tree they came from.

Materials: Bark; Leaves; Branches; Pinecones; Acorns; Sorting Trays

Morning Meeting

Question of the Day: What are the different parts of a tree?

Vocabulary: Roots; Trunk; Branches; Leaves; Bark; Seeds

Read Aloud

Featured Book: Tell Me, Tree by Gail Gibbons

Explore the different parts of a tree and discuss why each part is important for helping the tree survive.

Small Group Investigation

Build a Tree

Children assemble a paper tree using pre-cut roots, trunk, branches, and leaves while discussing the purpose of each part.

Materials: Construction Paper; Glue; Scissors; Tree Templates

Science Investigation

Exploring Tree Bark

Invite children to examine several pieces of bark using magnifying glasses. Encourage them to compare colors, patterns, textures, and thickness.

Which bark feels rough? Which bark feels smooth? Which bark is the thickest? Why do you think trees have bark?

Math Investigation

Count the Leaves

Count leaves collected from different trees and compare which groups have more, fewer, or the same number.

Interest Areas

Blocks: Build a large tree using wooden blocks and natural materials.

Art: Paint using leaves, branches, and pinecones instead of brushes.

Library: Read books showing different kinds of trees around the world.

Discovery: Compare bark, leaves, branches, and seeds with magnifying glasses.

Writing: Draw and label the parts of a tree.

Dramatic Play: Pretend to be park rangers teaching visitors about trees.

Outdoor Exploration

Choose one tree and identify each part together: Roots; Trunk; Branches; Leaves; Bark.

Music & Movement

Act out the life cycle of a growing tree. Begin as a seed. Grow roots. Stretch into a trunk. Reach out with branches. Wave leaves in the breeze.

Reflection Circle

What part of a tree did you learn today? Why are roots important? Which part surprised you the most?

Family Connection

Invite families to identify the roots, trunk, bark, branches, and leaves on a neighborhood tree together.

Thursday

How Trees Help Living Things

Arrival Invitation

Set out toy woodland animals, birds, insects, pinecones, sticks, and leaves. Invite children to build habitats and discuss why animals need trees.

Materials: Toy Animals; Bird Figures; Leaves; Sticks; Pinecones; Wooden Blocks

Morning Meeting

Question of the Day: Who lives in trees?

Do birds need trees? Do squirrels need trees? How do trees help insects? How do trees help people?

Read Aloud

Featured Book: The Busy Tree by Jennifer Ward

Discuss the many animals that depend on trees for food, shelter, and safety.

Small Group Investigation

Build an Animal Home

Children use recycled materials to create homes for birds, squirrels, insects, or woodland animals.

Materials: Cardboard; Twigs; Leaves; Glue; Construction Paper

Science Investigation

Animals Need Trees

Observe pictures of birds, squirrels, insects, raccoons, and owls. Discuss how each animal depends on trees for food, shelter, protection, or raising their young.

Interest Areas

Blocks: Build a woodland habitat using blocks and natural materials.

Art: Create birds and nests using paper, feathers, and twigs.

Library: Read books about forest animals.

Discovery: Compare feathers, bark, leaves, and pinecones.

Dramatic Play: Pretend to be forest rangers helping wildlife.

Math: Count birds, nests, acorns, and pinecones.

Outdoor Exploration

Search for signs of wildlife living in or around trees including nests, feathers, holes, insects, and squirrel activity.

Music & Movement

Move like woodland animals. Fly like birds. Hop like squirrels. Crawl like insects. Stretch like tall trees.

Reflection Circle

Which animals use trees? How do trees help people? Why should we care for trees?

Family Connection

Invite families to watch for birds, squirrels, butterflies, or insects using trees during an evening walk.

Friday

Celebrating Our Tree Discoveries

Arrival Invitation

Invite children to revisit all of the natural materials collected throughout the week and create a classroom nature museum.

Materials: Leaves; Branches; Bark; Pinecones; Acorns; Magnifying Glasses

Morning Meeting

Question of the Day: What was your favorite thing you learned about trees?

What surprised you? What did you enjoy most? What would you like to learn next?

Tree Review Game

Show children leaves, bark, branches, seeds, and pinecones. Invite them to identify each object and explain how it is connected to a tree.

Small Group

Our Classroom Tree

Create one large classroom tree together. Each child adds a leaf with their name or a picture showing something they learned.

Literacy

I learned that trees...

Record each child's response and read them together during closing circle.

Outdoor Celebration

Visit your favorite tree one last time this week. Compare what children noticed on Monday with what they notice today.

Music & Movement

Celebrate the week by acting out the complete life of a tree from seed to giant forest tree.

Reflection Circle

What did you discover? What was your favorite activity? What do you still wonder about trees?

Teacher Documentation

Record children's observations, vocabulary, interests, and questions to guide Week Two.

Family Connection

Encourage families to visit a favorite tree over the weekend and continue observing how it changes throughout the seasons.

Week One Reflection

Throughout this week children became scientists, artists, readers, mathematicians, and explorers while investigating the amazing world of trees. Through play, observation, conversation, and discovery, children built foundational knowledge that will continue throughout the remainder of this study.

Children Explored: Leaves; Branches; Roots; Bark; Seeds; Pinecones; Forest Habitats

Skills Developed: Observation; Scientific Inquiry; Language Development; Sorting & Classifying; Fine Motor Skills; Creative Thinking; Cooperative Learning

Looking Ahead: During Week Two children investigate how trees grow, what trees need to survive, and how weather and seasons affect them.